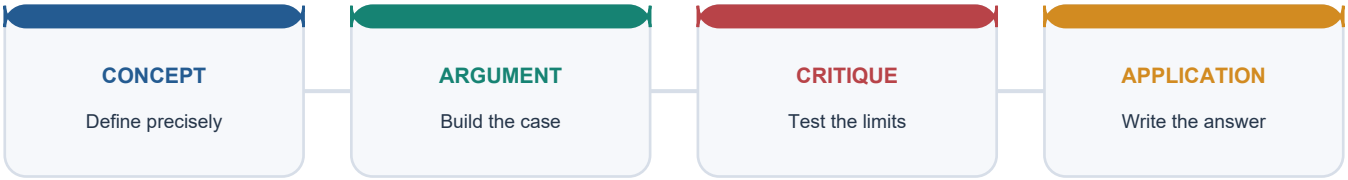
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Decline of the Sultanate: Timur, Sayyids & Lodis - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Decline of the Sultanate: Timur, Sayyids & Lodis - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 01

Question: Why was the founding of Agra under Sikandar Lodi historically significant?

- A. It provided a strategic centre closer to the doab, Rajasthan, Malwa and Gujarat-facing theatre.
- B. It was built as a coastal harbour for Indian Ocean trade.
- C. It abolished all rivalry with Afghan nobles.
- D. It marked Sikandar's withdrawal from north India.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Agra was chosen for military-geographical reasons, not as a decorative urban project alone.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Agra was chosen for military-geographical reasons, not as a decorative urban project alone.
- B. **Incorrect.** Agra is an inland Yamuna-side site controlling the doab-Rajasthan-Malwa axis; no source records it as a coastal harbour for Indian Ocean trade.
- C. **Incorrect.** Agra's founding was a strategic-administrative move; Afghan noble rivalry persisted through Sikandar's own reign and sharpened further under Ibrahim, so no rivalry was abolished.
- D. **Incorrect.** Founding a forward strategic base toward Rajasthan and Malwa strengthened, not withdrew, Lodi control of north India.

Trap: Do not treat Agra as a decorative or coastal foundation; its significance is inland strategy.

Workbook MCQ 02

Question: The gazz-i-Sikandari refers to:

- A. a Sayyid coin type.
- B. a standard unit of measurement associated with Sikandar Lodi's administration.
- C. a field artillery unit.
- D. a Timurid cavalry formation.

Answer: B.

Explanation: It is a classic administrative-marker fact tied to measurement and revenue supervision.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** It is a Lodi-era measurement standard, not a Sayyid coin; measurement units and coinage belong to different administrative categories.
- B. **Correct.** It is a classic administrative-marker fact tied to measurement and revenue supervision.
- C. **Incorrect.** Field-artillery vocabulary (carts, tulughma) belongs to Babur's Panipat battlefield system, not to Sikandar's revenue administration.
- D. **Incorrect.** Cavalry manoeuvre formations belong to Babur's Panipat vocabulary, a full generation after Sikandar's measurement reform.

Trap: Do not confuse the gazz-i-Sikandari with artillery, coinage or cavalry formations.

Workbook MCQ 03

Question: Which description best captures Sikandar Lodi's religious-cultural profile?

- A. An anti-literary ruler hostile to Persian learning.
- B. A purely liberal ruler with no coercive religious action.
- C. An administratively able ruler whose orthodoxy coexisted with significant literary patronage and cultural activity.
- D. A ruler who excluded all Hindus from office and language learning completely.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The safe reading is mixed and source-bounded, not one-word moral labelling.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Sources record Sikandar's patronage of Persian learning and poetry, the opposite of literary hostility.
- B. **Incorrect.** Sources also report orthodox and temple-restrictive episodes, so a "purely liberal" label erases half the evidence.
- C. **Correct.** The safe reading is mixed and source-bounded, not one-word moral labelling.
- D. **Incorrect.** This overstates exclusion into an absolute claim the sources do not support; it converts a mixed record into a flattened one.

Trap: Avoid one-word moral labels for Sikandar Lodi's religious-cultural profile.

Workbook MCQ 04

Question: Which factor most directly opened the way for Babur's intervention against Ibrahim Lodi?

- A. Portuguese naval support to Daulat Khan.
- B. The disappearance of Punjab politics.
- C. The instant collapse of all regional states.
- D. Conflict between Ibrahim and major Afghan nobles such as Daulat Khan and Alam Khan.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Internal Lodi fracture created the political corridor through which Babur advanced.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Daulat Khan's appeal reached Babur in Kabul, a Central Asian land power; Portuguese naval activity on the western coast has no connection to this Punjab-Delhi crisis.
- B. **Incorrect.** Punjab politics did not disappear; Daulat Khan's governorship and eventual defection is precisely what stayed active and opened the corridor.
- C. **Incorrect.** Regional states such as Mewar, Gujarat and Bengal remained active players, not collapsed actors, at this moment.
- D. **Correct.** Internal Lodi fracture created the political corridor through which Babur advanced.

Trap: Do not detach Babur's intervention from the political corridor opened by Lodi elite fracture.

Workbook MCQ 05

Question: Which statement about Panipat is correct?

- A. Babur's army was smaller but fought with a more integrated battle-system of artillery, carts, tactical gaps and cavalry manoeuvre.
- B. Babur deliberately fought without any field preparation.
- C. Ibrahim Lodi had no elephants at all.
- D. The battle was won before armies met.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Coordination, not mere numbers, explains Babur's battlefield success.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Coordination, not mere numbers, explains Babur's battlefield success.
- B. **Incorrect.** Babur's cart/*araba* barrier and prepared defensive line are direct evidence of deliberate field preparation, not its absence.
- C. **Incorrect.** Chronicled accounts describe a sizeable Lodi force including elephants; the safe point is about Babur's integration, not a claim that Ibrahim had none.
- D. **Incorrect.** This denies the actual manoeuvre and fighting (artillery, carts, tulughma, cavalry) that decided the engagement.

Trap: Do not convert Panipat into a simple head-count story; its force lay in integrated battle-planning.

Workbook MCQ 06

Question: The tulughma/tulghuma tactic is best understood as:

- A. a chronicle by Yahya bin Ahmad.
- B. a flanking and enveloping cavalry manoeuvre within Babur's battle-plan.
- C. grain taxation under Sikandar.
- D. temple endowment under the Sayyids.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Tulughma refers to mobile divisions used to envelop and outmanoeuvre the enemy.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi wrote the *Tarikh-i Mubarak Shahi*, a text, not a battlefield manoeuvre.
- B. **Correct.** Tulughma refers to mobile divisions used to envelop and outmanoeuvre the enemy.
- C. **Incorrect.** Grain-octroi abolition is a Sikandar Lodi revenue measure, unrelated to Babur's battlefield tactics decades later.
- D. **Incorrect.** Temple endowment is a religious-institutional matter, not a military manoeuvre term.

Trap: Do not mistake a tactical term for a chronicle, tax or architectural label.

Workbook MCQ 07

Question: Which explanation best rejects the "guns alone" myth?

- A. Artillery was irrelevant.
- B. Victory was caused only by Timurid bloodline.
- C. Babur's success came from firearms integrated with leadership, fortification, manoeuvre and Lodi political weakness.
- D. Ibrahim lacked war elephants.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Topic 06 treats technology as effective only when embedded in organisation and command.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** This swings to the opposite extreme; artillery mattered, just not in isolation from organisation and leadership.
- B. **Incorrect.** Lineage claims do not explain battlefield coordination, fortification and manoeuvre.
- C. **Correct.** Topic 06 treats technology as effective only when embedded in organisation and command.
- D. **Incorrect.** A narrow logistical claim about elephants does not by itself reject or explain the "guns alone" myth.

Trap: Technology mattered at Panipat only through organisation, manoeuvre and leadership.

Workbook MCQ 08

Question: Which statement about the date of Panipat is safest in this repository's usage?

- A. The repository rejects all textbook dates.
- B. The battle occurred in 1498.
- C. The exact date is unknowable and must never be mentioned.
- D. The battle is commonly given as 21 April 1526, but repository caution notes that some local source handling has also preserved 20 April; the key is to flag the variance honestly if needed.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The export follows repository caution rather than pretending there is no date-variant issue in the local source trail.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** The repository does not reject dates outright; it flags one specific day-variant caution while retaining the commonly given date.
- B. **Incorrect.** 1498 predates Sikandar Lodi's own reign and Babur's Kabul base, making it chronologically impossible for this event.
- C. **Incorrect.** The commonly given date can and should be stated, with the variance flagged honestly rather than suppressed as unknowable.
- D. **Correct.** The battle is commonly given as 21 April 1526, but repository caution notes that some local source handling has also preserved 20 April; the key is to flag the variance honestly if needed.

Trap: A repository caution note on the Panipat date must be reported honestly rather than suppressed or invented away.

Workbook MCQ 09

Question: Which statement best captures the immediate result of Babur's victory?

- A. It ended Lodi dynastic rule at the centre but did not instantly create uncontested Mughal rule across India.
- B. It made Bengal part of Babur's secure empire the same week.
- C. It erased all Afghan resistance immediately.
- D. It transferred power directly to the Portuguese.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Panipat was decisive dynastically, not immediately final territorially.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Panipat was decisive dynastically, not immediately final territorially.
- B. **Incorrect.** Bengal remained an independent eastern sultanate well beyond 1526, entirely untouched by the Panipat outcome.
- C. **Incorrect.** Afghan resistance continued for years and later resurfaced strongly under the Surs; it was not erased immediately.
- D. **Incorrect.** The Portuguese were a coastal trading power with no connection to this inland dynastic succession.

Trap: Dynastic victory is not the same as immediate, uncontested territorial consolidation.

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: Which administrative feature is most visible in the Lodi recovery of the Delhi-Agra core?

- A. Refusal to found or support urban centres.
- B. Greater attention to account-checking, measurement, roads and agrarian order.
- C. Complete abandonment of revenue supervision.
- D. Replacement of cavalry by an all-infantry militia.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Lodi recovery worked through military-fiscal rebuilding, not administrative withdrawal.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Agra's founding is direct evidence of urban centre-building, the opposite of refusing to found or support cities.
- B. **Correct.** Lodi recovery worked through military-fiscal rebuilding, not administrative withdrawal.
- C. **Incorrect.** Rent-rolls, account-checking and jagir-accounting show tightened, not abandoned, revenue supervision.
- D. **Incorrect.** Cavalry remained central to Lodi and later Panipat-era warfare; no all-infantry replacement is recorded.

Trap: Administrative recovery means more supervision, not state withdrawal.

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: Which statement about Sayyid-Lodi architecture is safest?

- A. It was exclusively wooden architecture.
- B. It abandoned all tomb building.
- C. It includes square and octagonal tomb forms, high platforms and transitional features important for later Mughal funerary architecture.
- D. It had no connection with later Mughal garden-tomb development.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The late Sultanate-Lodi phase is an architectural bridge, especially in tomb design and landscape setting.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** The surviving Sayyid-Lodi tombs are stone/rubble masonry structures, not wooden ones.
- B. **Incorrect.** Tomb building is precisely what defines this phase's architectural record, not its abandonment.
- C. **Correct.** The late Sultanate-Lodi phase is an architectural bridge, especially in tomb design and landscape setting.
- D. **Incorrect.** Platform and garden-tomb features are usually read as a direct bridge toward later Mughal funerary architecture such as Humayun's tomb.

Trap: Do not push Sayyid-Lodi architecture out of the larger transition toward Mughal funerary design.

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: Why should Bara Gumbad and Shish Gumbad be handled carefully in Topic 06?

- A. Because they belong only to ancient history.
- B. Because they are Jain cave monasteries.
- C. Because they were built by Babur in Kabul.
- D. Because exact attribution and chronology debates require caution even when they illustrate the broader Lodi architectural world.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Topic 06 uses them as bounded examples, not as a licence for overconfident monument trivia.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** These are Lodi-era medieval monuments, not structures belonging to the ancient period.
- B. **Incorrect.** They are Lodi-period built tomb/mosque complexes, not rock-cut Jain monasteries.
- C. **Incorrect.** They are Delhi-based Lodi constructions, unconnected to Babur's Kabul career.
- D. **Correct.** Topic 06 uses them as bounded examples, not as a licence for overconfident monument trivia.

Trap: Illustrative monuments still require attribution and chronology caution.

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: Which source is most closely associated with the Timurid courtly victory tradition?

- A. Sharaf al-Din Ali Yazdi's *Zafarnama*.
- B. Abbas Sarwani's Afghan narrative.
- C. Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi's *Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi*.
- D. Afif's *Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi*.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Yazdi is central to the Timurid courtly narrative, though still agenda-laden.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Yazdi is central to the Timurid courtly narrative, though still agenda-laden.
- B. **Incorrect.** Abbas Sarwani's narrative belongs to the later Sur-Afghan historiographical tradition, not the Timurid court.
- C. **Incorrect.** Sirhindi's chronicle is a Sayyid-era Delhi-centred work, not a Timurid courtly victory narrative.
- D. **Incorrect.** Afif's work covers Firuz Shah Tughlaq's reign, a generation before Timur's invasion.

Trap: One court chronicle cannot be read as transparent fact without agenda-awareness.

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: What is the safest statement about the *Tuzuk-i-Timuri / Malfuzat-i-Timuri* tradition?

- A. It proves Timur intended a settled all-India empire.
- B. It must be treated with authenticity caution and used comparatively, not literally as unquestioned autobiography.
- C. It is Babur's memoir under another name.
- D. It is a Mughal land-revenue manual.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The source is valuable chiefly as a source problem and ideological tradition, not as transparent self-authored fact.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** The memoir tradition is court self-justification, not proof of a settled-empire intention, and Timur's actual conduct of raid-then-withdrawal contradicts it.
- B. **Correct.** It must be treated with authenticity caution and used comparatively, not literally as unquestioned autobiography.
- C. **Incorrect.** Babur's own memoir is the separate *Baburnama*, a different text from a different generation.
- D. **Incorrect.** It is a conqueror's memoir/chronicle tradition, not an administrative revenue document.

Trap: Treat memoir traditions as source problems, not automatic autobiography.

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: Which statement best uses the *Baburnama* safely for Topic 06?

- A. It is a neutral military log with no self-fashioning.
- B. It was written by Ibrahim Lodi after Panipat.
- C. It is a vivid first-person source for campaign detail and self-representation, best checked against politics, material evidence and later outcomes.
- D. It is useless because memoirs are always false.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The memoir is exceptionally valuable, but still a ruler's account.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** As a ruler's memoir it carries self-representation, so calling it neutral with "no self-fashioning" overstates its objectivity.
- B. **Incorrect.** Ibrahim Lodi died at Panipat; the text is Babur's own account, not his defeated opponent's.
- C. **Correct.** It is a vivid first-person source for campaign detail and self-representation, best checked against politics, material evidence and later outcomes.
- D. **Incorrect.** This is an overcorrection; once cross-checked the memoir remains valuable first-person evidence, not automatically false.

Trap: A vivid first-person text still demands cross-checking against politics and outcomes.

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: A student writes that the fifteenth century was either a restored Delhi empire or uniform collapse. Which correction is safest?

- A. A fully restored unitary Delhi empire.
- B. A timeless war of races.
- C. Uniform economic collapse from Bengal to Gujarat.
- D. Political fragmentation at the old centre combined with regional state vitality and selective economic recovery.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is the core interpretive sentence of the topic.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Delhi's fifteenth-century reach was contracted, not restored to unitary empire scale.
- B. **Incorrect.** This replaces political-structural explanation with an essentialist ethnic frame the topic explicitly rejects.
- C. **Incorrect.** Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa and Jaunpur show continued economic and cultural vitality, not uniform collapse.
- D. **Correct.** Political fragmentation at the old centre combined with regional state vitality and selective economic recovery.

Trap: Do not collapse regional vitality into an all-India story of death and emptiness.

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: Which statement about the economy and society of the age is strongest?

- A. Political fragmentation did not prevent recovery in centres such as Delhi, Agra, Punjab and the doab, especially under the later Lodis.
- B. All trade routes disappeared permanently after 1398.
- C. Persian ceased to matter in administration.
- D. Urban life vanished from north India for a century.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Topic 06 avoids confusing political contraction with total economic death.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Topic 06 avoids confusing political contraction with total economic death.
- B. **Incorrect.** Timur's raid disrupted Delhi but did not permanently erase regional and long-distance trade routes.
- C. **Incorrect.** Persian chancery practice continued through the Sayyid-Lodi period into Mughal administration.
- D. **Incorrect.** Agra's founding and Delhi's continued function as a capital contradict a century-long urban vanishing.

Trap: Political fragmentation did not erase agrarian and urban recovery everywhere.

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: What is the best distinction between symbolic claim and durable rule?

- A. Durable rule required no revenue or army.
- B. A ruler could possess khutba, coin or dynastic symbolism without commanding deep and stable coercive control everywhere.
- C. They are always identical in medieval history.
- D. Symbols never mattered politically.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This distinction is crucial for reading the Sayyids and also Timur's shadow over Delhi.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Durable rule depended precisely on stable revenue and military capacity, the opposite of needing none.
- B. **Correct.** A ruler could possess khutba, coin or dynastic symbolism without commanding deep and stable coercive control everywhere.
- C. **Incorrect.** The Sayyid case shows symbolic authority and durable coercive control diverging, not merging into identity.
- D. **Incorrect.** Khutba and coinage carried real legitimacy value; the caution concerns their limits, not their irrelevance.

Trap: Khutba, coin or dynastic shadow are not identical to deep and stable coercive control.

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: The "Delhi to Palam" trope is mainly used to indicate:

- A. the Sayyid conquest of all Punjab.
- B. the building of a new river canal to Palam.
- C. the dramatic shrinkage of the Delhi sultan's effective authority and prestige.
- D. Delhi's maritime expansion.

Answer: C.

Explanation: It is a literary image of contraction and humiliation, not a cartographic measurement.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** The phrase describes contraction of authority, the opposite of a conquest claim.
- B. **Incorrect.** No canal project is associated with this phrase; it is a rhetorical image, not an infrastructure record.
- C. **Correct.** It is a literary image of contraction and humiliation, not a cartographic measurement.
- D. **Incorrect.** Delhi is an inland city; the phrase concerns a nearby inland locality, not maritime expansion.

Trap: The 'Delhi to Palam' image is rhetorical contraction, not cartographic measurement.

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Which concluding thesis is most appropriate for Topic 06?

- A. The Lodis failed because Afghans were biologically unfit for monarchy.
- B. The Delhi Sultanate fell only because Timur attacked.
- C. Panipat was purely a gunpowder miracle.
- D. The decline of Delhi was a long structural and political transition in which regionalisation, elite fracture, fiscal-military strain, Timur's raid and Babur's organised intervention all mattered.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is the full multi-causal conclusion expected in a high-quality GS-I answer.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** This is an essentialist ethnic explanation the topic explicitly rejects in favour of political-structural analysis.
- B. **Incorrect.** This is the single-cause trap the topic corrects; pre-existing fragmentation predates Timur's 1398 raid.
- C. **Incorrect.** This isolates artillery from the organisational and political factors the topic insists must accompany it.
- D. **Correct.** The decline of Delhi was a long structural and political transition in which regionalisation, elite fracture, fiscal-military strain, Timur's raid and Babur's organised intervention all mattered.

Trap: A strong conclusion must keep structural, political, military and regional causes in one frame.

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: Which statement is false?

- A. Delhi's decline automatically means that all of India experienced total collapse in the same way.
- B. Regional states could remain active while Delhi weakened.
- C. A shrinking centre and resilient provinces can coexist.
- D. Political fragmentation and selective economic recovery are compatible.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The main trap of the topic is to confuse Delhi's contraction with India-wide death.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Delhi's decline automatically meaning total India-wide collapse in the same way is the false statement; the main trap of the topic is to confuse Delhi's contraction with India-wide death.
- B. **Incorrect as an answer.** This statement is true: regional states did remain active while Delhi weakened, so it is not the false one being sought.
- C. **Incorrect as an answer.** This statement is true: a shrinking centre and resilient provinces coexisted throughout this period.
- D. **Incorrect as an answer.** This statement is true: Agra's founding and Jaunpur's cultural florescence show fragmentation and selective recovery are compatible.

Trap: Never equate Delhi's decline with identical collapse across all of India.

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: Which statement is the strongest correction to the phrase "Timur conquered India"?

- A. He never entered India at all.
- B. He conducted a devastating raid on Delhi and the north-west, then withdrew rather than building durable all-India rule.
- C. He was defeated before reaching Punjab.
- D. He ruled from Agra for twenty years.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Topic 06 distinguishes raid, plunder and symbolic aftermath from settled conquest.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Timur did enter India and reached Delhi in 1398; this denies a well-established event.
- B. **Correct.** He conducted a devastating raid on Delhi and the north-west, then withdrew rather than building durable all-India rule.
- C. **Incorrect.** No defeat is recorded before Punjab; his forces advanced through Punjab to Delhi and prevailed there.
- D. **Incorrect.** Timur withdrew soon after the sack of Delhi and never established a twenty-year administered rule from any Indian city.

Trap: Timur raided and withdrew; he did not build durable all-India rule.

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: Which statement is correct?

- A. Khizr Khan had no relation at all to Timurid legitimacy claims.
- B. The Sayyids permanently eliminated Jaunpur and Malwa.
- C. The Sayyid polity is best seen as weak sovereignty centred on Delhi rather than as a massive reconquest empire.
- D. The Sayyids restored the empire of Alauddin Khalji in full.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The Sayyids mattered symbolically, but their coercive reach remained limited.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Khizr Khan's rule is explicitly linked to a Timurid relationship and assignment in the sources, so "no relation at all" overstates the opposite.
- B. **Incorrect.** Jaunpur and Malwa remained active regional powers through the Sayyid period; Jaunpur's elimination came later, under Bahlul Lodi.
- C. **Correct.** The Sayyid polity is best seen as weak sovereignty centred on Delhi rather than as a massive reconquest empire.
- D. **Incorrect.** Sayyid authority was territorially restricted around Delhi, far short of Alauddin Khalji's earlier extensive conquests.

Trap: Sayyid importance was symbolic-political, not imperial reconquest.

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: Which statement best corrects the phrase "Afghan equality"?

- A. Afghan nobles rejected every kind of rank.
- B. Afghan politics meant modern universal democracy.
- C. Afghan rulers always partitioned India peacefully.
- D. Afghan elite culture often involved strong claims to consultation and shared honour among nobles, but it was still embedded in hierarchical state politics.

Answer: D.

Explanation: "Equality" here is an elite political idiom, not a modern social doctrine.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Afghan politics still recognised chiefs and hierarchy among lineages; rejecting "every kind of rank" is too absolute.
- B. **Incorrect.** This anachronistically imports a modern political concept onto elite noble bargaining among armed chiefs.
- C. **Incorrect.** Bahlul's own partition among sons and relations created later succession strain, not a guaranteed peaceful outcome.
- D. **Correct.** Afghan elite culture often involved strong claims to consultation and shared honour among nobles, but it was still embedded in hierarchical state politics.

Trap: Afghan consultation does not mean modern mass democracy.

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: Which statement about Sikandar Lodi is most misleading?

- A. His reign can be described simply as either complete tolerance or total civilisational darkness.
- B. He is associated with gazz-i-Sikandari and account scrutiny.
- C. His reign mixed stronger administration with sharper juristic-religious policies.
- D. He founded Agra for strategic reasons.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Topic 06 rejects flat moral binaries; the other three statements are defensible and source-grounded.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Describing his reign as either complete tolerance or total civilisational darkness is the most misleading statement; Topic 06 rejects flat moral binaries.
- B. **Incorrect as an answer.** This statement is factually defensible and source-grounded, not misleading.
- C. **Incorrect as an answer.** This balanced framing is exactly the source-grounded reading the topic endorses, not a misleading one.
- D. **Incorrect as an answer.** This is an accurate, well-evidenced statement about Agra's founding, not a misleading one.

Trap: Sikandar should not be flattened into pure tolerance or pure darkness.

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: Which statement best corrects the image of Ibrahim Lodi as merely a passive weakling?

- A. He had no political will whatsoever.
- B. He attempted to strengthen monarchy, but this sharpened conflict with Afghan nobles and relatives.
- C. He voluntarily surrendered to Babur before battle.
- D. He ruled only Kashmir.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Ibrahim's failure came partly from an assertive but politically costly centralising push.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** His active drive to discipline and centralise over Afghan nobles is itself evidence of political will, not its absence.
- B. **Correct.** He attempted to strengthen monarchy, but this sharpened conflict with Afghan nobles and relatives.
- C. **Incorrect.** Ibrahim died fighting at Panipat rather than surrendering to Babur beforehand.
- D. **Incorrect.** Ibrahim ruled the Delhi-based Lodi Sultanate, not a Kashmir-confined territory.

Trap: Ibrahim failed through conflict-ridden assertion, not through simple passivity.

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: Which statement about Panipat is correct?

- A. Babur won without any preparation or tactical innovation.
- B. Ibrahim's army was politically united and tactically superior.
- C. Panipat shows how firearms mattered when combined with fortification, manoeuvre and leadership.
- D. Firearms were irrelevant to the battle.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The trap is to isolate guns from the battle-system that made them effective.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** The cart/*araba* barrier and *tulughma* manoeuvre are direct evidence of deliberate preparation and innovation, not its absence.
- B. **Incorrect.** Ibrahim's army was weakened by noble defection and factional conflict, the opposite of political unity.
- C. **Correct.** Panipat shows how firearms mattered when combined with fortification, manoeuvre and leadership.
- D. **Incorrect.** This denies the documented role of field artillery within Babur's integrated battle-system.

Trap: Firearms mattered through battle-system integration, not isolation.

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: Which statement best corrects the phrase "1526 instantly created the Mughal Empire in all India"?

- A. Babur never took Delhi.
- B. Ibrahim survived and ruled for ten more years.
- C. Panipat was a small skirmish of no consequence.
- D. Panipat ended Lodi dynastic rule at the centre, but Babur still faced Rajput and Afghan resistance before wider consolidation.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Topic 06 repeatedly distinguishes dynastic victory from full imperial consolidation.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Babur's victory at Panipat led directly to his occupation of Delhi; he did take the city.
- B. **Incorrect.** Ibrahim Lodi was killed at Panipat in 1526, ending his rule immediately, not ten years later.

- C. **Incorrect.** Panipat ended Lodi dynastic rule at the centre, a consequence far beyond a minor skirmish.
- D. **Correct.** Panipat ended Lodi dynastic rule at the centre, but Babur still faced Rajput and Afghan resistance before wider consolidation.

Trap: 1526 ended Lodi central rule but not all Afghan and Rajput resistance.

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: Which statement is correct?

- A. The *Tuzuk/Malfuzat* tradition needs authenticity caution and comparative reading.
- B. It is a revenue survey of Agra.
- C. It is unquestionably Timur's autograph manuscript.
- D. It completely replaces Yazdi and Indian chronicles.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Source criticism is central to this topic.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Source criticism is central to this topic.
- B. **Incorrect.** It is a memoir/chronicle tradition, not a fiscal survey, and predates the Lodi-era founding of Agra.
- C. **Incorrect.** Its authenticity and transmission are themselves disputed, so "unquestionably autograph" overstates a certainty the topic withholds.
- D. **Incorrect.** The topic treats it as one source among several to be cross-checked, not a replacement for other chronicle traditions.

Trap: Source criticism is core method here, not decorative garnish.

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: Which statement best distinguishes Jaunpur in Topic 06?

- A. It was irrelevant to Delhi.
- B. It was the strongest eastern rival whose defeat mattered to Bahlul Lodi's consolidation.
- C. It functioned only as a temple town without state power.
- D. It was conquered by Timur and ruled from Samarqand.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Jaunpur is a serious regional-state actor, not a decorative footnote.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Jaunpur under the Sharqis was Delhi's major eastern rival, the opposite of irrelevant.
- B. **Correct.** It was the strongest eastern rival whose defeat mattered to Bahlul Lodi's consolidation.
- C. **Incorrect.** Jaunpur was a functioning Sharqi kingdom with its own court and military power, not merely a temple town.
- D. **Incorrect.** Timur's 1398 campaign targeted Delhi and the north-west; Jaunpur's conquest came later, by Bahlul Lodi, not Timur.

Trap: Jaunpur was a real rival state, not a decorative appendix to Delhi.

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: Which statement is correct?

- A. Every route and market died permanently after 1398.
- B. Urban life vanished permanently from the Delhi-Agra region after Timur.
- C. Political fragmentation did not prevent roads, agrarian recovery and urban revival in parts of north India.
- D. Persian stopped spreading in administration.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Recovery in the Delhi-Agra-doab core is a major counter-trap in the topic.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** This overstates Timur's raid into a permanent, total economic death the sources do not support.
- B. **Incorrect.** Agra's later founding and Delhi's continued function as a capital contradict a permanent urban vanishing.
- C. **Correct.** Political fragmentation did not prevent roads, agrarian recovery and urban revival in parts of north India.
- D. **Incorrect.** Persian chancery practice continued through the Lodi period, not halted after Timur's raid.

Trap: Selective recovery can coexist with fragmentation.

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: Which statement best captures the architectural value of the Sayyid-Lodi phase?

- A. It should be ignored because chronology debates exist.
- B. It is valuable only for fort walls.
- C. It has no relation to Mughal architecture.
- D. It offers transitional tomb forms, platform use and garden settings that help explain later Mughal funerary developments.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Caution about individual monuments does not cancel the broader architectural significance of the phase.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** Attribution and chronology debates call for caution in detail, not for ignoring the phase altogether.
- B. **Incorrect.** The phase's main architectural significance lies in tomb forms and garden settings, not fort walls specifically.
- C. **Incorrect.** Platform and garden-tomb features are read as a direct bridge to later Mughal funerary architecture.
- D. **Correct.** It offers transitional tomb forms, platform use and garden settings that help explain later Mughal funerary developments.

Trap: Chronology caution does not erase the transitional architectural value of the Sayyid-Lodi phase.

Remediation map - predictable errors and their correcting Workbook MCQs

Predictable learner error	Correcting Workbook MCQs
Treating Agra as decorative, coastal or politically marginal	01, 10
Confusing gazz-i-Sikandari with military technology or coinage	02
Flattening Sikandar Lodi into a single moral label	03, 25
Ignoring Ibrahim Lodi's conflict with Afghan nobles and relatives	04, 26
Treating Panipat as guns-alone determinism	05, 06, 07, 27

Predictable learner error	Correcting Workbook MCQs
Treating 1526 as instant all-India Mughal consolidation	08, 28
Mishandling Timurid, Baburnama or memoir-source evidence	13, 14, 15, 29
Equating Delhi's decline with India-wide collapse	16, 21, 31
Confusing symbolic claim with durable sovereignty	18, 22, 23, 30
Downgrading Jaunpur and the regional-state system	04, 16, 30
Forgetting selective recovery in the Delhi-Agra-doab core	09, 16, 17, 31
Missing the transitional value of Sayyid-Lodi architecture	11, 12, 32

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified and honestly-adjacent PYQs

Adjacent PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 (adjacent chronology route; wording verified locally, option row partly OCR-garbled)

Question as securely verified from local OCR: Consider the following statements:

1. It was during the reign of Iltutmish that Chengiz Khan reached the Indus in pursuit of the fugitive Khwarezm prince.
2. It was during the reign of Muhammad bin Tughluq that Taimur occupied Multan and crossed the Indus.
3. It was during the reign of Deva Raya II of Vijayanagara Empire that Vasco da Gama reached the coast of Kerala.

Option-row status: The local OCR preserves the combination row imperfectly, but earlier validated repository usage supports the standard set containing "1 only", "1 and 2", "3 only" and "2 and 3".

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: 1 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is correct because Chinggis Khan reached the Indus in 1221 while pursuing Jalal al-Din Mangburni during Iltutmish's reign. Statement 2 is incorrect because Timur's Indian invasion belongs to the post-Firuz phase and culminates in 1398, far after Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Statement 3 is incorrect because Vasco da Gama reached Kerala in 1498, not in Deva Raya II's time.

Why this earns marks: It secures chronology and prevents the common error of attaching every north-west frontier episode to Muhammad bin Tughlaq.

Demand decoding: Frame a decline answer that links succession politics, elite fragmentation, fiscal-military strain, provincial assertion, Timur's catalytic raid and Panipat's limited finality without collapsing the whole story into one cause.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Verify each statement independently, eliminate by chronology, and state clearly that the key used here is inferred from locally preserved wording rather than an officially held answer row in this package.

How to improve this answer: Add one sentence showing why the closest distractor fails on chronology so the elimination method becomes explicit, not assumed.

Adjacent PYQ 02 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent frontier chronology; wording verified locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: (b) 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure on India predates Jalaluddin Khalji. Statement 2 is correct because a major Mongol attack reached Delhi during Alauddin's reign. Statement 3 is not supported in the secure form used in this repository.

Why this earns marks: It separates early frontier pressure from the famous Delhi-siege moment and trains ruler-event discipline.

Demand decoding: Answer comparatively: define the chronology problem, verify each frontier statement separately, and avoid projecting Timur or later Lodi-Babur events back onto earlier Mongol episodes.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Test each statement against ruler chronology, then eliminate options one by one; finish by separating what is securely supported from what the repository does not endorse in this topic's bounded scope.

How to improve this answer: Name the exact ruler-event mismatch in the rejected statement so the examiner sees a specific chronological correction rather than a guess.

Adjacent PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (adjacent but highly useful source-criticism question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for reconstructing medieval India because they preserve the language of kingship, conquest, moral anxiety, administrative aspiration and courtly self-fashioning. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only when read with **genre and patronage caution**.

For Topic 06, this method is essential. Timurid victory narratives and later memoir traditions present violence, piety and legitimacy through the conqueror's lens. Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi is crucial for the Sayyid world, but he also writes from within a courtly-political frame. *Baburnama* gives vivid first-person detail for the road to Panipat, yet it remains ruler-self-representation, not neutral reportage. Earlier texts such as Barani and Afif likewise reveal the assumptions of elite Persianate politics more fully than the experience of peasants, women or local vernacular communities.

These works therefore reflect the age in a **refracted** way: they reveal the values of courts, officials, warriors and legitimising intellectuals. Their silence on subaltern life, and their tendency to moralise success and failure, require constant checking against coins, inscriptions, architecture and regional evidence.

Hence Persian literary sources do reflect the spirit of the age - but mainly the political and ideological spirit of elite society. Used critically and comparatively, they become powerful historical evidence rather than decorative quotation.

Why this earns marks: It turns the word *reflect* into a method question, names applicable source families and shows both value and limitation.

Demand decoding: Treat this as a source-method question: explain why Persian literary texts are indispensable yet agenda-laden, then show how Topic 06 reads Timurid, Sayyid and Babur-era texts critically.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with a thesis on value plus limitation; then move through Timurid narratives, Sirhindi, the Baburnama and earlier Persian chronicles before closing with coins, inscriptions and architecture as material checks.

How to improve this answer: Strengthen the answer by adding one explicit line on whose experience Persian courtly texts do not represent well.

Adjacent PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (adjacent Sultanate-wide technology question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period mattered technologically because it accelerated the diffusion, adaptation and systematisation of techniques in construction, irrigation, warfare and administration. Its importance lay less in isolated inventions than in the **social use of technology for state-building**.

In building, the stronger use of the true arch, dome and lime mortar changed both engineering possibility and the symbolism of power. In irrigation, canals associated with Firuz Shah show technology tied directly to agrarian expansion and revenue growth. In administration, branding, descriptive rolls, measurement practices and revenue accounting improved the capacity of rulers to supervise men, horses, produce and assignment holders. Topic 06 also reminds us that by the early sixteenth century, firearms and field artillery had entered Indian warfare more systematically; Panipat showed how technology mattered most when integrated with battle-organisation.

These changes influenced society unevenly. They strengthened capitals, roads, agrarian cores and military-fiscal extraction more than they democratised life. Monumental construction supported courtly urbanity; irrigation expanded cultivation; accounting practices sharpened control over intermediaries; and gunpowder-era methods began to reshape elite warfare.

Thus Sultanate technology influenced society chiefly by enlarging **state capacity, urban growth and military transformation**, while also deepening hierarchy and resource mobilisation.

Why this earns marks: It connects technology with irrigation, architecture, administration and Panipat without reducing the issue to weapons alone.

Demand decoding: Treat technology as a society-and-state question: identify the main technological changes, then explain their social effect without reducing the answer to guns alone.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Group the answer into architecture, irrigation, administration and warfare; use Panipat only as a bounded example of how technology mattered through organisation and state capacity.

How to improve this answer: Add one sentence separating technological adoption from automatic social progress so the answer remains analytical rather than celebratory.

PYQ verification ledger and scope honesty

- No direct standalone UPSC PYQ devoted only to Timur's raid, the Sayyids, Bahlul, Sikandar or Ibrahim was verified locally in the bounded repository audit set used for this export.
- The package therefore uses **adjacent but honest** PYQs on chronology, Persian sources and Sultanate technology.
- No coaching-question stem is relabelled as an official UPSC PYQ.

Original solved Mains questions

Mains 01 - 10 marks

Question: Explain the structural causes of the fragmentation of the Delhi Sultanate after 1388. (Answer in 150 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** The fragmentation after 1388 was structural, not merely the product of weak successors.
- **Evidence / source line:** Satish Chandra's concise and Part I discussions emphasise succession disorder, noble-centre conflict, provincial assertion and geographical-regional factors. Topic 05 adds Firuz's hereditary office and weakened military discipline.
- **Mechanism:** Open succession encouraged civil war; hereditary offices strengthened service families; muqtis and regional commanders retained resources; cavalry-fort maintenance strained finances; distance and ecology favoured provincial autonomy; local agrarian-commercial bases could sustain rival courts.
- **Significance:** Once Delhi's aura dimmed, Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa and Jaunpur no longer behaved like temporary rebels but as viable states.
- **Limitation:** Rulers still mattered; structure did not make collapse automatic.
- **Verdict:** The Sultanate fragmented because institutions of succession, extraction and command were too weak to survive repeated shocks.

Why this earns marks: It moves beyond the cliche of weak successors and builds a five-factor answer with causation.

Demand decoding: The demand is explanatory and bounded: define why Firuz's later arrangements hardened elite interests and then show how that weakened post-1388 central discipline without wandering into Timur or Panipat.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Use a three-step structure-hereditary office and assignments, stronger service families and factional autonomy, then reduced capacity of the centre to reshuffle, punish and command. End by linking these changes to the later fragmentation problem.

How to improve this answer: Name the institutional channel more sharply-iqta/assignment control, office-holding families, slave-noble power-so the answer reads as mechanism, not generic decline language.

Mains 02 - 10 marks

Question: Assess the impact of Timur's invasion on the Delhi Sultanate. (Answer in 150 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** Timur's 1398 raid was a devastating catalyst, not the sole cause of the Sultanate's decline.
- **Evidence / source line:** Local OCR stresses sack, killings, plunder and the carrying away of artisans; the concise volume also says Timur's political effect was limited because he did not stay, yet the invasion marked the end of strong Delhi rule.
- **Mechanism:** The raid destroyed life and wealth in Delhi, deepened prestige collapse, enlarged the political vacuum and encouraged frontier and provincial actors such as Khizr Khan.
- **Significance:** It accelerated transition from late Tughlaq weakness to Sayyid weak sovereignty.
- **Limitation:** Regional vitality elsewhere continued; India as a whole was not conquered or permanently destroyed.
- **Verdict:** Timur's invasion was a decisive blow to Delhi's core authority, but it operated within a longer process of structural fragmentation already underway.

Why this earns marks: It balances devastation, causation and continuity without either minimising or apocalyptic exaggeration.

Demand decoding: This is an assessment question: measure Timur's impact by combining immediate devastation, prestige collapse and political openings with the longer structural weakness that predated the raid.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with the thesis that Timur was a devastating catalyst, then move through sack and plunder, prestige collapse, openings for actors such as Khizr Khan, and a final qualification that India as a whole was not conquered or uniformly destroyed.

How to improve this answer: Make the numerical caution explicit by noting that casualty and loot figures are reported claims, while the fact of severe devastation is secure.

Mains 03 - 15 marks

Question: "The Sayyid dynasty preserved the symbol of Delhi more than the substance of empire." Examine. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** The statement is substantially correct.
- **Evidence / source line:** Topic 06 owner files and local OCR place Khizr Khan's Delhi recovery in 1414 under a Timurid legitimacy shadow, while also noting that the Sayyids never became strong empire-builders. The dynasty faced Khokhars in Punjab, Mewatis and Sharqi Jaunpur.
- **Mechanism:** Delhi remained valuable as a symbol of sovereignty, khutba and courtly precedence. However, control beyond the core required negotiated tribute, intermittent campaigns and compromise with local chiefs. The gap between claim and enforcement widened.
- **Significance:** The Sayyid phase shows how a state can survive through **symbolic centrality** even after the high-capacity imperial machine has thinned out. It explains why Bahlul Lodi could later take Delhi and still inherit prestige from the city.
- **Limitation:** Weak sovereignty should not be read as zero importance. Mubarak Shah especially tried to act more assertively, and Delhi still mattered strategically.
- **Verdict:** The Sayyids preserved the throne's symbolic relevance, but not the broad coercive reach of the Khalji-Tughlaq zenith.

Why this earns marks: It defines symbolism and substance separately and uses them as analytical categories, not rhetoric.

Demand decoding: The command is analytical, not descriptive: explain why the Sayyid dynasty preserved the symbol of Delhi more than the substance of empire by separating prestige from coercive reach.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Start with Khizr Khan's Timurid shadow and Delhi recovery, then explain tribute politics, limited territorial depth, regional pressures and the distinction between symbolic centrality and strong empire.

How to improve this answer: A stronger answer also states that Sayyid descent was claimed rather than proven and avoids language implying either no authority at all or a restored empire.

Mains 04 - 15 marks

Question: Analyse Sikandar Lodi's contribution to the reconstruction of north-Indian monarchy. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** Sikandar Lodi was the most effective Lodi ruler and the chief architect of the dynasty's administrative consolidation.
- **Evidence / source line:** Local OCR credits him with making nobles honour farmans, demanding jagir accounts, ensuring justice, safe roads, cheap prices, abolishing grain octroi, introducing gazz-i-Sikandari and founding Agra in 1506.
- **Mechanism:** He reduced the autonomy of Afghan nobles through court discipline and audit; strengthened the military-fiscal core through measurement and supervision; and shifted strategic focus eastward and southward through Agra. Agrarian and road security improved the revenue base.
- **Significance:** Under Sikandar, Delhi recovered enough to become once more a serious north-Indian monarchy rather than merely a symbolic seat. His reign also demonstrates that political fragmentation did not preclude material recovery.
- **Limitation:** His coercive religious actions and orthodoxy complicate any celebratory picture; moreover, noble bargaining remained structurally unresolved and resurfaced sharply under Ibrahim.
- **Verdict:** Sikandar reconstructed monarchy through discipline, supervision and strategic urban policy, but could not eliminate the contradictions of Afghan-Lodi kingship.

Why this earns marks: It joins political authority, revenue supervision and urban geography in one integrated answer.

Demand decoding: This asks for comparison inside one reign: show how Sikandar combined administrative strengthening with a religious-cultural record that cannot be flattened to one label.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Organise the answer into administration (Agra, accounts, gazz-i-Sikandari, octroi, roads/justice), then religion/culture (orthodoxy, coercive episodes, Persian learning and patronage), and end with a balanced judgement.

How to improve this answer: Add one sentence explaining why the same reign could sustain literary culture and sharper juristic policy simultaneously; that analytical bridge raises the answer above a list.

Mains 05 - 20 marks

Question: Panipat (1526) was won by Babur not because of firearms alone, but because of a superior military-political system. Discuss. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** Firearms mattered, but Panipat was fundamentally a victory of coordinated system over disjointed mass.
- **Evidence / source line:** Part II OCR names Ustad Ali and Mustafa, cart-lines tied by rawhide ropes, tactical gaps, artillery and tulughma manoeuvre. It also stresses Ibrahim's larger host and the continuing factional weakness of the Lodi camp.
- **Mechanism:** Babur used artillery from prepared positions, protected it with carts, preserved mobility through gaps, and enveloped with tulughma cavalry. This tactical design multiplied the value of firearms. Leadership cohesion mattered equally: Babur commanded one organised plan, whereas Ibrahim drew upon a politically strained

coalition less capable of flexible response.

- **Political setting:** Daulat Khan and Alam Khan had already exposed Lodi fracture. Thus battlefield technology rested on prior political disunity.
- **Significance:** Panipat marks the transition to a new style of north-Indian warfare in which gunpowder, fortification and manoeuvre increasingly worked together.
- **Limitation:** It would still be wrong to claim that all Indian polities were helpless before guns; later battles show adaptation.
- **Verdict:** Babur won because firearms were embedded in superior organisation, command, fieldcraft and political timing.

Why this earns marks: It directly addresses the word "alone" and integrates technology with tactics, leadership and politics.

Demand decoding: The question asks for causal integration: show how Babur's tactical superiority worked together with Ibrahim's political isolation rather than replacing politics with technology.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Use two paired halves-first Ibrahim's conflict with Afghan nobles and the Punjab opening; then Babur's artillery, araba, tulughma, cavalry and disciplined command. The conclusion must state why 'guns alone' is insufficient.

How to improve this answer: Make the coalition dimension explicit by naming Daulat Khan or Alam Khan and by noting that Panipat's success rested on a more coherent political-military system, not only better equipment.

Mains 06 - 20 marks

Question: "The decline of the Delhi Sultanate was also an age of regionalisation, selective recovery and historical transition." Evaluate. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

- **Claim:** The statement is the most accurate way to read the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries.
- **Evidence / source line:** Part I explicitly warns against reading the age simply as decadence and decline. Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur and other regional powers remained active. Topic 06 also shows Delhi's urban-political disruption after Timur, Sayyid weak sovereignty, Lodi recovery and Panipat's non-finality.
- **Mechanism:** After 1388, succession disorder, fiscal-military strain and provincial autonomy weakened Delhi. Timur's 1398 raid deepened that crisis. Yet regional agrarian-commercial bases sustained alternative courts and cultural centres. Under the Lodis, especially Sikandar, the Delhi-Agra-doab core recovered through roads, supervision, measurement and strategic urban policy.
- **Transition dimension:** Babur's victory at Panipat ended Lodi dynastic rule but did not erase administrative continuities or regional resistance. Thus the period links the high Sultanate to the early Mughal order.
- **Limitation:** Regionalisation should not obscure the severe damage suffered by Delhi itself; nor should recovery be overstated into full imperial restoration.
- **Verdict:** The age was one of contraction at the centre, vitality in the regions and eventually a military-political transition to Mughal supremacy.

Why this earns marks: It avoids both collapse-romance and progress-romance, which is exactly what examiners reward in higher-order answers.

Demand decoding: This is a concluding synthesis: you must explain why 1526 marks dynastic replacement and transition while still preserving institutional continuity and unfinished consolidation.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with Panipat as a watershed; then show Lodi central collapse, Babur's inheritance of administrative forms, regionalisation plus selective recovery, and the need for further warfare before wider consolidation. Close with continuity through change.

How to improve this answer: The answer improves when it names the surviving institutional forms-Persian chancery, revenue assignments, mints, qazis-and pairs them with later battles to prove that continuity and incompleteness coexisted.